TEXORA · LECTURE SHEET

Design Principles

How the elements are arranged: balance, proportion, emphasis, rhythm, harmony and contrast — the principles that turn colour, fabric, silhouette and line (Topic 4) into a design that holds together.

AM-4203 · FASHION DESIGN AND PRODUCT ENGINEERING · TOPIC 5 · LEVEL 4 TERM 2

1. Principles are testable, not taste

A principle differs from a preference: it states a relation that can be checked in the design itself. "The two sides do not balance" can be verified on the croquis; "I don't like it" cannot. The six principles below are the standard working set of apparel design. Each is stated with its garment test, because a designer uses them as instruments while a design is still changeable.

2. Balance

Balance is the equal distribution of visual weight about a centre — for a garment, normally the centre-front vertical. Visual weight is created by size, darkness, brightness, texture and detail: a small dark motif can balance a large pale one. Three forms:

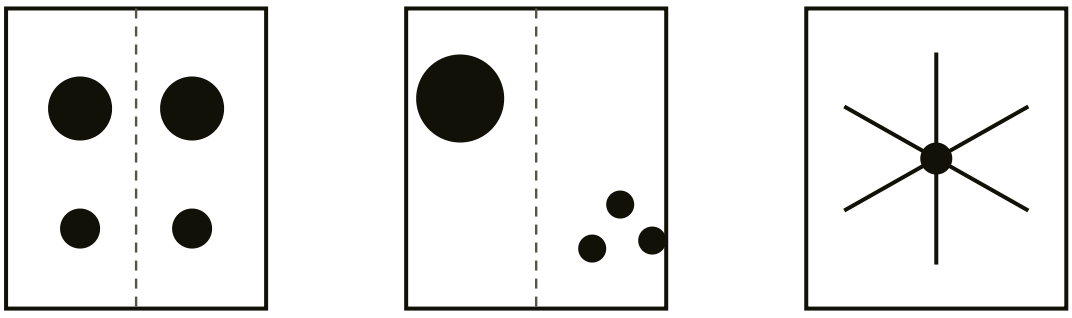


Figure 1 — The three balances. In the asymmetrical panel the single large motif is balanced by the cluster of three small ones: equal weight, unequal form.

- **Symmetrical (formal) balance:** the two sides mirror each other — the natural balance of most garments, giving order, dignity and rest. A centred button column with matched pockets is symmetrical.

- **Asymmetrical (informal) balance:** the sides differ but their visual weights are equal — one shoulder drape balanced by a hip detail, a single large motif balanced by several small ones. It gives movement and interest and is harder to judge: the test is whether the design feels level, not whether the sides match.
- **Radial balance:** parts radiate from a central point — sunray pleats from a waist point, a motif spreading from the neck. Strong and decorative, used in doses.

3. Proportion

Proportion is the relation of sizes between parts — bodice to skirt, sleeve to body, motif to panel, the wearer's divisions to the garment's. The eye reads proportion against the body's own divisions (Topic 2): a waistline placed exactly at the natural waist divides the figure evenly; raising or lowering it lengthens one part at the expense of the other, which is a tool, not an error, when done deliberately. Unequal divisions are generally more interesting than equal ones — the classical guide is the golden ratio, approximately **1 : 1.618**, seen in divisions like 3:5 or 5:8; a bodice:skirt of 3:5 sits more comfortably than 1:1 (which cuts the figure in half) or 1:3 (which strands the longer part). Proportion also governs scale: a large check on a small garment, or a tiny motif on a wide skirt, fails by scale before it fails by anything else.

4. Emphasis, rhythm, harmony, contrast

PRINCIPLE	STATEMENT AND GARMENT TEST
Emphasis	Every design should have one dominant focal point to which colour, line and detail direct the eye (the brightest colour, the decoration of Topic 3, the converging lines). Test: cover parts of the design in turn — the eye should return to the same point. Two equal emphases cancel each other and leave the design restless.
Rhythm	Movement created by repetition — of buttons, pleats, stripes, motifs, colour — regular repetition gives a steady beat; graduated repetition (sizes growing or spacing widening) gives a flowing, directional rhythm. Rhythm is what carries the eye around the whole garment instead of abandoning it at the focal point.
Harmony / unity	The parts belong together: elements share something — a colour family, a line direction, a texture level, a theme (Topic 6) — so the design reads as one statement. Test: remove any part; in a unified design the remainder looks incomplete, not relieved.
Contrast	Deliberate opposition — dark against light, smooth against rough, fitted against loose — used to create emphasis and prevent monotony. Contrast is a seasoning: total contrast everywhere produces noise; none produces blandness. It is the controlled exception inside harmony, not its enemy.

5. The principles working together: a check sequence

1. Cover the design's centre line: does each side's weight feel equal (balance)?
2. Measure the main divisions against the body and against each other: are the ratios intended (proportion)?
3. Look for three seconds: where did the eye land first, and is that the intended point (emphasis)?
4. Follow the repetitions: do they carry the eye around the garment (rhythm)?
5. Ask what single idea the parts share (harmony) — and where the one deliberate exception is (contrast).

Glossary

TERM	MEANING
Visual weight	The attention a part attracts, from its size, darkness, brightness, texture and detail combined.
Proportion	The size relations among a design's parts and between the design and the body.
Golden ratio	The proportion ≈ 1 : 1.618, a classical guide for pleasing unequal divisions.
Rhythm	Eye movement produced by repetition, regular or graduated, of an element.
Unity	The quality by which all parts of a design read as belonging to one statement.

Key points and summary

- Balance distributes visual weight: symmetrical (mirror), asymmetrical (equal weight, different form), radial (from a point).
- Proportion relates part sizes to each other and to the body; unequal ratios such as 3:5 are generally stronger than equal halves.
- One emphasis, rhythm by repetition, unity by shared character, contrast as the controlled exception.
- The five-question check of §5 applies the principles in working order to any design.

Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. A dress has a large dark motif on the left shoulder and nothing elsewhere. Using balance, state the fault and two different corrections.

2. A skirt of 60 cm is divided by a horizontal band into 30 cm + 30 cm. Suggest a better division using §3 and give the two lengths.
3. Define rhythm in a garment and name the repetition that creates it in (a) a pleated skirt, (b) a striped shirt.
4. "Harmony and contrast are opposites, so a design must choose one." Correct the statement.

Answer key

1. The left side carries nearly all the visual weight, so the design is unbalanced. Corrections: (1) mirror the motif on the right shoulder (symmetrical balance); or (2) keep the single motif and add smaller, lighter detail at the opposite hip — for example a small cluster of motifs — until the weights feel equal (asymmetrical balance).
2. Equal halves are the weakest division. A 3:5 division of 60 cm gives 22.5 cm + 37.5 cm — the band placed so the parts stand in the golden-ratio family rather than in halves.
3. Rhythm is the eye's movement created by repetition. (a) The repeated pleats — regular repetition, steady beat. (b) The repeated stripes — the eye travels along and across them in sequence.
4. They are complementary tools, not alternatives: harmony unifies the whole, and a measured contrast inside it creates the emphasis that keeps unity from blandness. A design needs both — unity overall, contrast in a controlled dose.

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